

1929 Books, Films, More to Enter Public Domain Next Month

Popeye the Sailor and the Belgian boy reporter Tintin lead the class of characters and works of art to enter public domain in 2025.

On January 1, 2025, the U.S. copyright ends on creations from 1929. That means the early versions of the comic characters can be used without permission or payment.

They will be joined by the books *A Farewell to Arms* by Ernest Hemingway and *The Sound and the Fury* by William Faulkner. Other works coming into the public domain include songs from American artist Cole Porter, early films from Alfred Hitchcock and the Marx Brothers, and several more films starring Mickey Mouse, whose earliest version became public domain last year.

“It’s a trove! There are a dozen new Mickey cartoons — he speaks for the first time and dons the familiar white gloves,” said Jennifer Jenkins, director of the Center for the Study of the Public Domain, part of Duke University Law School in North Carolina.

“There are masterpieces from Faulkner and Hemingway, the first sound films from Alfred Hitchcock, Cecil B. DeMille, and John Ford, and amazing music from Fats Waller, Cole Porter, and George Gershwin. Pretty exciting,” she added.

Here is a closer look from the Associated Press at this year’s crop of public domain works:

Comics characters

Popeye the Sailor, with his big arm muscles and fighting spirit, was created by E.C. Segar and made his first appearance in the newspaper comic strip *Thimble Theater* in 1929. His first words were, “’Ja think I’m a cowboy?” when asked if he was a sailor. It was supposed to be a one-time appearance for the character. Instead, he became the main character, and the strip would be renamed *Popeye*.

But as with Mickey Mouse last year and Winnie the Pooh in 2022, only the earliest version is free for reuse. Popeye did not become a film character until 1933 and that version remains under copyright.

The 1929 version of the character Tintin, the creation of Belgian artist Hergé, will also come into the public domain. The simply drawn teenager with dots for eyes and hair shaped like an ocean wave, was among the most popular characters in Europe for much of the 20th century.

However, in much of the world, Tintin will not become public property until 70 years after the 1983 death of his creator.

This combination of photos show authors Ernest Hemingway in 1950, left, William Faulkner in 1950, center, and John Steinbeck in 1962. (AP Photo)

Important American books

The books entering the public domain this year read like a list for an American literature class.

The Sound and the Fury is arguably William Faulkner's most famous book. Its special style of expression was a big hit although the book was widely considered difficult to read and understand. The story is set in the southern state of Mississippi, where Faulkner was born and lived most of his life. It tells about the ruin of a leading family there.

And Ernest Hemingway's A Farewell to Arms joins his earlier The Sun Also Rises in the public domain. The story about an ambulance driver is set in Italy during World War I. It was based in part on Hemingway's real life. It has been made into film, TV, and radio versions, and now can be done anew without permission.

American John Steinbeck's first novel, A Cup of Gold, will also enter the public domain.

Movies

Filmmaking was changing from silent to sound production during the late 1920s.

The famous moviemaker Alfred Hitchcock was still living in Britain when he made the film Blackmail. The movie began as a silent film but was turned to sound film during production. Two versions of Blackmail were released. One of the versions became Britain's and Hitchcock's first sound film.

American John Ford is probably best remembered for making the kind of films called Westerns. Those movies remain protected. But, Ford's first sound film, 1929's The Black Watch, enters the public domain next month. The action movie includes a young John Wayne who appears in a small part. Years later, Wayne was the star of many Ford films.

Another notable director, Cecil B. DeMille, already a Hollywood leader in silent films, made Dynamite his first sound film in 1929.

Groucho, Harpo, and the other Marx Brothers humor group had their first starring parts in 1929's The Cocoanuts. The brothers went on to make the popular comedies, Animal Crackers and Duck Soup.

And The Broadway Melody will also enter the public domain on January 1. It became the first sound film and the second film ever to win the Oscar for best picture — then called “outstanding production.”

FILE - First lady Eleanor Roosevelt appears with opera singer Marian Anderson in Richmond, Virginia July 2, 1939, as Anderson is presented with the Spingarn Medal. to the singer. (AP Photo, File)

Music

Songs from the last year of the 1920s are also about to become publicly available for use.

Cole Porter's compositions What Is This Thing Called Love? and Tiptoe Through the Tulips are among the highlights, as is the jazz classic Ain't Misbehavin' written by Fats Waller and Harry Brooks.

Different laws cover sound recordings. Those newly in the public domain date to 1924. They include a recording of Nobody Knows the Trouble I've Seen from star and civil rights icon Marian Anderson, and Rhapsody in Blue performed by its composer George Gershwin.

I'm Caty Weaver. And I'm Dorothy Gundy.

The Associated Press' Andrew Dalton reported this story. Caty Weaver adapted the report for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

character - n. ตัวละคร

public domain - n. สาธารณสมบัติ (สถานะทางกฎหมายที่งานสร้างสรรค์อยู่นอกเหนือการคุ้มครองลิขสิทธิ์และสามารถใช้งานหรือทำซ้ำได้อย่างอิสระโดยสาธารณะ)

trove - n. ชุมทรัพย์, ของสะสมล้ำค่า

dozen - n. โหล (จำนวนสิบสอง)

cartoon - n. การ์ตูน (ชุดภาพวาดง่ายๆ ที่เล่าเรื่อง หรือภาพยนตร์ที่สร้างจากภาพง่ายๆ คล้ายกัน)

don - v. สวมใส่

comic strip - n. การ์ตูนช่อง, การ์ตูนสั้นในหนังสือพิมพ์ (ชุดภาพวาดง่ายๆ สั้นๆ ที่เล่าเรื่องตลกมักจะตีพิมพ์ในหนังสือพิมพ์เป็นประจำ)

style - n. ลักษณะเฉพาะ, รูปแบบ (วิธีการทำสิ่งใดสิ่งหนึ่งที่มียอดประกอบที่จดจำได้และโดดเด่น)

composition - n. บทเพลง, การประพันธ์ดนตรี

classic - adj. คลาสสิก, ผลงานชิ้นเอก (สิ่งที่ถือว่าเป็นหนึ่งในตัวอย่างที่ดีที่สุดของกลุ่มที่สังกัดอยู่)

icon - n. บุคคลที่เป็นสัญลักษณ์, ผู้เป็นที่เคารพ (บุคคลที่เป็นตัวแทนของความคิดหรืออุดมคติ)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What significant event is anticipated for several well-known characters and artworks in 2025, as mentioned in the article's introduction?

They will receive new film adaptations.

They will enter the public domain.

Their original creators will be honored.

They will be featured in a special exhibition.

2. According to the article, when do U.S. copyrights for creations from 1929 officially conclude?

December 31, 2024

January 1, 2025

July 4, 2025

At the end of the year the creator dies

3. Which of the following literary works is specifically named as entering the public domain in 2025?

The Great Gatsby by F. Scott Fitzgerald

To Kill a Mockingbird by Harper Lee

A Farewell to Arms by Ernest Hemingway

1984 by George Orwell

4. Jennifer Jenkins highlights a particular development regarding Mickey Mouse's entry into the public domain this year. What is it?

His first full-length movie will be released.

He will appear in a new video game.

He speaks for the first time and wears white gloves in new cartoons.

His original creator will be revealed.

5. Besides comic characters and Mickey Mouse cartoons, what other categories of creations does Jennifer Jenkins specifically mention as exciting additions to the public domain?

Modern video games and documentaries

Masterpieces from Faulkner and Hemingway, first sound films, and amazing music

Digital art and interactive media

Live theatrical performances and sculptures

6. What is the primary purpose of the section introduced by the phrase 'Here is a closer look from the Associated Press at this year's crop of public domain works'?

To provide a summary of legal copyright changes.

To offer a detailed examination of specific works entering the public domain.

To discuss the financial implications for copyright holders.

To introduce new legislation affecting public domain.

7. When Popeye the Sailor first appeared in the comic strip Thimble Theater, what was his intended role?

He was immediately the main character of the strip.

He was a recurring villain.

He was meant to be a one-time appearance.

He was a silent observer.

8. What restriction applies to the public domain status of characters like Popeye and Mickey Mouse?

All versions of the characters are now free for reuse.

Only versions released after 1933 are protected.

Only the earliest versions are free for reuse, while later versions may remain copyrighted.

Their public domain status is only temporary.

9. Who is credited with the creation of the character Tintin?

E.C. Segar

Ernest Hemingway

Hergé

Alfred Hitchcock

10. How does Tintin's public domain status differ between the U.S. and 'much of the world'?

Tintin is already public property globally.

In the U.S., it's based on publication year, while elsewhere it's 70 years after the creator's death.

Tintin will remain copyrighted in the U.S. indefinitely.

Outside the U.S., Tintin will never enter the public domain.

11. Which statement accurately describes William Faulkner's book 'The Sound and the Fury'?

It was a straightforward and easy-to-read novel.

It is set in New York City and focuses on industrial development.

It is arguably his most famous book, known for its special style and being difficult to read.

It was his first novel and a commercial failure.

12. Ernest Hemingway's 'A Farewell to Arms' draws inspiration from what aspect of his life?

His childhood experiences in Africa.

His time as a journalist in Paris.

His experiences as an ambulance driver in Italy during World War I.

His adventures as a fisherman in the Caribbean.

13. What made Alfred Hitchcock's film 'Blackmail' particularly noteworthy during its production?

It was the first film to use color technology.

It was entirely filmed in a single take.

It began as a silent film but was converted to a sound film during production.

It featured an entirely unknown cast.

14. Which John Ford film, featuring a young John Wayne in a small part, is specifically mentioned as entering the public domain?

Stagecoach

The Searchers

The Black Watch

Grapes of Wrath

15. What significant achievement is associated with the film 'The Broadway Melody' as it enters the public domain?

It was the first film to be shot in Technicolor.

It was the first silent film to win an Oscar.

It became the first sound film and the second film ever to win the Oscar for best picture.

It was the highest-grossing film of the 1920s.